

S

A

B

C

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F

TIER

Every ILIST letter

Growth Channel,

Ranked



I'll break down **30 ways** to grow your
newsletter / email list and which are
best

Why it's important

- There's a ~100% chance you're using growth sources that are a **WASTE** of time and money
- *Not* all newsletter subscribers are created equal.
- In fact, subscribers from some sources are **worth 50–100 times *more*** than others.

**Most people don't realize how
much MORE money you can make
with a quality list of 5,000 people
and a good offer Vs a crap list of
100,000**

The data

- After running my numbers, I found the The difference in conversion rate from free subscribers to buyers between my best sources Vs worst sources was **6648%**!
- That means these signups were 6000%+ MORE valuable.
- I found the same data patterns across clients, and I'll break it all down at the end of this video.

A	B	C	D
Acquisition Source	Subscribers	Buyers	CVR
Website Direct	16870	834	4.94%
GrowLetter.co (Home Page)	316	7	2.22%
Bing	140	3	2.14%
LinkedIn	1431	29	2.03%
YouTube	1648	26	1.58%
Google search	4081	64	1.57%
Twitter / X	7101	64	0.90%
Twitter / X ads	4600	25	0.54%
Meta ads	31773	122	0.38%
Recomendation	3323	2	0.06%
Boosts	2811	1	0.04%
Organic sources	31587	1027	3.25%
Paid social ads	36373	147	0.40%
Rec's and Boosts	6134	3	0.05%
CVR Difference between Rec's and Boosts Vs Paid social ads	826%	8.3	
CVR Difference between Rec's and Boosts Vs Organic sources	6648%	66.5	

If you're new here, I'm Matt McGarry, founder & CEO of GrowLetter



the **HUSTLE**

Robinhood 

1440

 **FOOTBALLGUYS**

Money

chart**r**

 **NAUTILUS**

 **The Neuron**

 the pour over

BANKLESS[®]

 **BUILT TO SELL**


THE MILKROAD

**I've helped clients add 10M+ email
subscribers and \$100M+ in sales**



I'm ranking 30 growth channels across 6 categories:

- Paid Social
- Organic Social
- Paid Search & Discovery
- Paid Recommendations
- Organic Growth Tactics
- Partnerships & PR

The ranking criteria:

- Scalability
- Cost per subscriber
- Time investment required
- Subscriber quality (OR, CTR, & conversion to customer)

All based on real experience and data!

Organic Social

YouTube

- High quality subscribers
- Multiple monetization paths
- Builds deep audience connection
- Content lives forever (SEO benefit on YouTube and Google)

CONS: Time and money

YouTube

- Rank: S tier

LinkedIn

- High quality subscribers
- Great B2B creators and brands
- Good post can get views for ~1 week
- Algorithm favors genuine engagement (conversations)
- You can DM your connections

CONS: Doesn't work for all niches

LinkedIn

- Rank: S Tier

Instagram

- Reels can go viral even if you have a low follower count
- Works for any niche or industry
- You can DM followers
- Stories for CTAs

CONS: You must master short video

Instagram

- Rank: S Tier

SubStack Notes

- Last of the last social platforms for written content
- 1-click subscribe to your newsletter
- Simple to use

CONS: New and unproven, less users, must link to your substack newsletter, not for every niche / industry

SubStack Notes

- Rank: B tier (could be an A tier soon)

Twitter/X

- Great for *some* niches: News, tech, investing, crypto
- Algorithm is unpredictable and video focused
- Reach has declined significantly
- Harder to convert to email

Twitter/X

- Rank: C Tier

TikTok

- Virality potential with a small amount of followers
- Young-ish audience – less sophisticated
- Hard to convert to email
- Can't DM followers

CONS: All video, inconsistent, less financially valuable leads

TikTok

- Rank: C Tier

Podcast

- Deep audience connection

CONS:

- Massive time investment
- Hard to convert listeners to subscribers
- Better alternative channels exist for newsletter growth

Podcast

- Rank: D Tier

Paid Social

Why paid social matters:

- It's scalable and measurable
- Gets you off the content treadmill
- All newsletters with 1M+ subscribers use paid social

However, it's not for everyone. Especially beginners.

Meta ads

- \$1-\$3 cost per subscriber
- 40%-50% open rate
- Best ROAS of any paid channel
- Infinitely scalable

CONS: Takes skill, learn the platform, and ad creative

Meta ads

- Rank: S Tier

LinkedIn ads

- Only for B2B
- Higher quality subscribers than Meta
- Professional targeting options
- 50%-60% open rates

CONS: More expensive (\$3-\$7 CPA), less scale

LinkedIn ads

- Rank: B Tier

Twitter/X ads

- Lower CPMs than Meta
- Decent engagement (45%-60% opens)

CONS: Bots, buggy, can't scale, shit ad tech

Twitter/X ads

- Rank: E Tier
- Use use Meta instead

TikTok ads

- Like Meta ads, but worse
- Higher costs, lower quality, less scale
- TikTok has emphasized the shop platform more than the ad platform.

TikTok ads

- Rank: C Tier

SEM: SEO & Paid Search

SEO – Organic Search

- High intent subscribers (actively searching for your topic)
- Repurpose content from your newsletter
- Content *can* works for years
- Good SEO benefits AI SEO

CONS: AI disruption cutting traffic, long term growth channel, you must master e-cap

SEO – Organic Search

- Rank: A tier

Google ads

- High intent, high quality subscribers
- Great ROAS if you have a high LTV / high-ticket product

CONS: High CPA (\$5–\$10), hard to scale, requires specific search volume

Google ads

- Rank: B Tier

Partnerships & Collaboration

Why partnerships work:

- Position yourself as an expert through an implied endorsement
- Borrow other people's audiences
- High quality, pre-warmed traffic
- Grow without spending money

Guest newsletter / blog posts

- Super high-quality subscribers
- Builds relationships and authority
- Get a backlink (helps SEO and domain authority)

CONS: Relationships, takes time, not as scaleable (hard to do more than 1 per month), need clear CTA

Guest newsletter / blog posts

- Rank: B tier

Be a podcast guest

- Host promotes you
- Builds your authority
- Subscribers come in pre-sold
- No production work on your end

CONS: Relationships, existing authority, outreach takes time, need clear CTA

Be a podcast guest

- Rank: B tier

Newsletter ads (buy ads in *other* newsletters)

- By far the BEST subscriber quality
- 60%-70% open rates
- 10%-25% click rates
- \$5-\$15 CPA

CONS: Manual and slow to scale, expensive, some newsletters flop, hard to find more than 2-3 newsletters that work, Then these sources get exhausted over time.

Newsletter ads (buy ads in *other* newsletters)

- Rank: C Tier

Cross-promotions.

- By far the BEST subscriber quality
- 60%-70% open rates
- 10%-25% click rates
- \$5-\$15 CPA

CONS: Manual and slow to scale, expensive, some newsletters flop, hard to find more than 2-3 newsletters that work, Then these sources get exhausted over time.

Cross-promotions.

- Rank: B Tier

Speaking

- Builds authority
- Super high quality subscribers
- Can drive 50–500+ signups per event (25% CVR)

CONS: Travel, relationships, expenses, opportunity cost

Speaking.

- Rank: C Tier

CROSS-PROMOTIONS - B TIER

CROSS-PROMOTIONS - B TIER

Quality varies wildly

Takes time to coordinate

Hard to scale

How to do it right:

Only partner with newsletters in your niche

Similar audience size and quality

Test small before going big

Track results religiously

SPEAKING - B TIER

High quality subscribers

Builds authority

Can drive 50-500+ signups per event

The downsides:

Very time intensive

Hard to scale

Results are unpredictable

Often requires travel

When it works:

You're a strong speaker

Events align with your niche

You're building a personal brand

***Other* Organic Growth Tactics**

The channels:

Referral programs

Giveaways

Forward to a friend

Online communities

Reality check: Most of these are overrated.

Referral Programs

- Sounds great in theory
- Rarely drives meaningful growth
- Requires rewards/incentives
- Time intensive to manage

Referral Programs

- Rank: C Tier

REFERRAL PROGRAMS - C TIER

Sounds great in theory

Rarely drives meaningful growth

Requires rewards/incentives

Time intensive to manage

When it works:

You already have 10k+ engaged subscribers

Your content is remarkable

You have rewards that matter

For most newsletters under 10k subscribers:

Focus on better content, not referral programs.

Giveaways

- Attracts freebie-seekers
- Low engagement after giveaway ends
- Time intensive
- Quality > quantity

Giveaways

- Rank: D Tier

GIVEAWAYS - C TIER

Attracts freebie-seekers

Low engagement after giveaway ends

Time intensive

Quality > quantity

When it works:

Prize is highly relevant to your niche

You verify new subscribers

You have follow-up strategy

Better approach:

Create great content and give it away for free (no gimmicks).

Foreword to a friend.

- Almost no one does it
- Even if they do, low conversion
- Better to use that space in the newsletter for something else

Foreword to a friend.

- Rank: E Tier

FORWARD TO A FRIEND - E TIER

Almost no one does it

Even if they do, low conversion

Better to just ask readers to share on social

Online communities

- Most communities ban self-promotion
- Time intensive (participating authentically)
- Easy to come across as spammy

Online communities

- Rank: E Tier

ONLINE COMMUNITIES - E TIER

Most communities ban self-promotion

Low conversion rates

Time intensive (participating authentically)

Easy to come across as spammy

When it works:

You're genuinely active and helpful

Community allows valuable self-promotion

Niche community with your exact ICP

The Worst Channels

These channels don't just "not work"...

***They could* actively damage your
newsletter.**

Paid Recommendations (and co-reg)

- SparkLoop Partner Network
- Beehiiv Boosts
- Co-reg

Paid Recommendations

- Rank: F Tier

PAID RECOMMENDATIONS - F TIER

Beehiiv Boosts

SparkLoop Partner Network

Refind

Traffic Grid

Why they're F-tier:

Subscribers never saw your website

They don't remember subscribing

They mark you as spam

Damages deliverability for everyone

The only benefit: Your ego (bigger list size)

Free Recommendations

- Substack recommendations
- beehiiv recommendations
- SparkLoop UpScribe
- Kit creator network

Free Recommendations

- Rank: E Tier

Why E-tier instead of F:

- Slightly better quality than paid
- Can work if highly targeted
- Free (no direct cost)

FREE RECOMMENDATIONS - E TIER

Substack recommendations

beehiiv free recommendations

SparkLoop UpScribe

Why E-tier instead of F:

Slightly better quality than paid

Can work if highly targeted

Free (no direct cost)

But still problematic:

Low engagement

Subscribers don't remember you

Hurts deliverability

CO-REG - F TIER

Checkbox opt-ins on other websites

Often bundled with other offers

Subscribers don't know what they signed up for

Why it's F-tier:

Terrible engagement

High spam complaints

Often violates email provider terms

Can get your domain blacklisted

Never. Ever. Use this.

Cold emails/newsletters.

- Scraping email lists
- Sending unsolicited newsletters / cold emails
- "Adding people who would be interested"

Co-Reg

- Rank: F Tier

COLD EMAILS/NEWSLETTERS - F TIER

Scraping email lists

Sending unsolicited newsletter signups

"Adding people who would be interested"

Why it's F-tier:

Illegal in many jurisdictions (CAN-SPAM, GDPR)

Instant spam complaints

Will get you blacklisted

Destroys your domain reputation

Don't even think about it.

List buying / newsletter buying.

- Buying email lists from brokers
- Buying other people's newsletters with the plan to add them to your list

Co-Reg

- Rank: E Tier

LIST BUYING/NEWSLETTER BUYING - E TIER

Buying email lists from brokers

Buying other people's newsletters

Why it's E-tier:

Subscribers didn't consent to YOU

Engagement craters immediately

Often fake/outdated emails

Damages reputation

The exception:

Acquiring a newsletter in your niche (properly)

With transparent handoff to subscribers

And re-permission campaign

Anon website traffic (Retention.com)

- Services that retarget anonymous website visitors
- Try to identify and email them (get them to join your newsletter or just send them your newsletter)

Anon website traffic

- Rank: E Tier

ANON WEBSITE TRAFFIC (RETENTION.COM) - E TIER

Services that retarget anonymous website visitors

Try to identify and email them

The results:

Very expensive

Low quality leads

Often feels creepy to recipients

Better to just run retargeting ads

Directories and aggregators

- Newsletter directories
- List aggregators
- "Submit your newsletter" sites

Directories and aggregators

- Rank: F Tier

DIRECTORIES & AGGREGATORS - F TIER

Newsletter directories

List aggregators

"Submit your newsletter" sites

Why they're F-tier:

Almost zero traffic

Low quality when traffic comes

Waste of time submitting

Do it once if you want, then forget about it.

Press coverage / PR

- Extremely time intensive
- Rarely drives meaningful subscribers
- Traffic spike doesn't convert well
- Hard to repeat

Press coverage / PR

- Rank: F Tier

PRESS COVERAGE/PR - F TIER

Extremely time intensive

Rarely drives meaningful subscribers

Traffic spike doesn't convert well

Hard to repeat

The exception:

Building general brand awareness

You have a big news story

PR is part of larger strategy

S

A

B

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TIER

LIST

RECAP

S-Tier (Start here):

- YouTube
- LinkedIn
- Instagram
- Meta Ads (if you're already monetizing)

A-Tier (Excellent options):

- SEO (Search)
- Substack Notes (almost in A)

B-Tier (Solid, can be great for some people):

- Google Ads
- LinkedIn Ads
- Be a podcast guest
- Cross-promotions

C-Tier (Usually a bad idea, but can be helpful for some)

E-Tier (Skip it, only works for rare exceptions)

F-Tier (Actively harmful)

My Recommendation

1 discovery, 1 partnership, 1 paid channel

Discovery:

- YouTube
- LinkedIn
- Instagram

Partnership:

- Guest NLs / posts
- Cross promos
- Pod guesting

Paid:

- Meta ads

**Don't even think about anything
else!**

Quality > Quantity

**Remember at the start when I said I'd
show you my actual data?**

Acquisition Source	Subscribers	Buyers	CVR
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CVR Difference between Rec's and Boosts Vs Organic sources	6648%	66.5	

Total subscribers: 87,000+

Total customers: 1,150+

Products sold: \$1,500+ each

Organic sources (31,587 subscribers)

- 1,027 buyers = 3.25% conversion rate
- These are my highest quality subscribers
- From: Website direct, LinkedIn, YouTube, Google search, Twitter/X

Paid social ads (36,373 subscribers)

- 147 buyers = ~0.40% conversion rate
- 8X worse than organic
- But still profitable and scalable
- From: Meta ads, Twitter/X ads

Paid and free recommendations (6,134 subscribers)

- 3 buyers = 0.05% conversion rate
- 65X worse than organic
- 8X worse than paid social
- Actively hurt my deliverability and engagement with entire list.

**Let me show you what this means in
dollars:**

Organic sources (31,587 subs)

1,027 buyers × \$1,500 = \$1,540,500 in revenue

Revenue per subscriber: \$48.76

Paid social ads (36,373 subs)

147 buyers × \$1,500 = \$220,500 in revenue

Revenue per subscriber: \$6.06

Recommendations (6,134 subs)

3 buyers × \$1,500 = \$4,500 in revenue

Revenue per subscriber: \$0.73

**I generated 342X more revenue per
subscriber from organic vs recs.**

What I Learned (And What You Should Do)

I removed inactive subscribers from these sources

- Anyone who hadn't clicked after 5 sends: DELETED
- This improved deliverability for everyone

I doubled down on what actually worked

- More LinkedIn content
- More YouTube videos
- Better SEO strategy
- Better Meta ads and funnels

I stopped obsessing over subscriber count

- Focus shifted to conversion rate
- Quality over quantity became the mantra

**Here's the sad part: Most newsletter
publishers will ignore this advice**

They'll keep using:

- Recommendations (because it's easy)
- Every growth channel (because more is better, right?)
- Vanity metrics (because 100k sounds better than 10k)

But the smart ones won't.

The smart ones will see that:

- ANY TYPE of subscriber that does not **intentionally** opt-in on a web page is USELESS
- The only benefit to using sources like this is to your **ego**
- Email list size is a vanity metric that does not matter

**Even open rate and CTR are LESS
important than you think, too.**

What matters is:

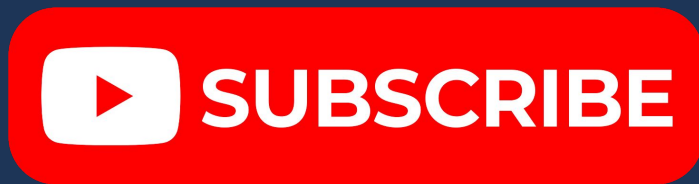
- New customers
- Free subscriber to paid customer conversion rate
- Customer satisfaction and success.
- Ad clicks and CTR on your sponsor's links.
- Sponsor renewal rate (they will renew if the traffic you send drives leads and sales)

**You will make MORE money with a
quality list of 5,000 people and a
good offer Vs a crap list of 100,000.**

Which one are you going to be?

That's it!

**If this is helpful, like this video
and subscribe to the channel!**



**The SLIDES and more free
resources are in the description
below**

